

Reading the Label

Every psalm has a line above it. *A Psalm of David. To the choirmaster: according to Lilies. A Song of Ascents. A Maskil of Asaph.* In most Bibles it sits in smaller type, unnumbered, above the first verse, and it reads like something the printer put there rather than something the book says.

So most of us skip it. I have skipped it for forty years. It looks like a filing note – the sort of thing a librarian writes on a card so a book can be found again, useful to whoever shelves it and of no interest to whoever reads it.

It is not a filing note. It is the only thing the psalm tells you about itself.

Read a psalm and you are asking one question: what does this say? It is the natural question and it is the right one. But the line above the psalm answers a different question, and it answers it before you begin.

| *What kind of thing is this, and how is it to be handled?*

Those come apart in Hebrew and collapse in English. Our word "psalm" covers all hundred and fifty, so every one of them arrives looking like the same kind of object. The Hebrew headings do not work that way. They name at least six different kinds of thing, and each name carries an instruction about how to take it.

One is marked *play this*. Another, *sing this*. Another says *this one is for thinking about* – and if that is what you are reading, then going at the pace you read the last one is a mistake.

The whole collection is named after the label that appears on one psalm out of a hundred and fifty.

There are six of them worth knowing, and the whole set fits on a page.

Mizmor – from *zamar*, to pluck a string. A piece with instruments under it. It is the commonest of all the labels, on fifty-seven psalms, and it appears nowhere in the Hebrew Bible outside this book. It tells you that what you are reading was never bare text. Somebody was playing while it was sung.

Shir – song. Voice rather than strings, and the ordinary Hebrew word for any song at all: the song at the sea, a work song, the Song of Songs. It tells you this was sung, and almost certainly not by one person alone.

Maskil – from *sakal*, insight, skill, understanding. Thirteen psalms carry it. It tells you to slow down. Whatever else this psalm is doing, it is teaching, and it expects to be worked at rather than read through.

Miktam – unknown. Six psalms have it, Psalm 16 among them, and nobody can say what it means. The guesses run from "inscription" to "atonement" to "a psalm to be sung quietly." The honest instruction is that there isn't one.

Tephillah – prayer. Five psalms say so, and there is a note at the end of Psalm 72: *the prayers of David are ended*. It tells you this is addressed to God rather than about him – which raises the question of what the other hundred and forty-five are doing.

Tehillah – praise. One psalm carries it. Psalm 145.

The last of those is the one that stops you.

Tehillah appears as a heading exactly once in a hundred and fifty psalms. And when Hebrew names this book, it does not call it Songs, or Prayers, or Poems. It calls it *Tehillim* – Praises. The whole collection is named after the label that appears on one psalm out of a hundred and fifty.

That is not a filing decision. Somebody read the entire book – the complaints, the arguments, the psalm that ends *darkness is my only companion*, the one that asks how long eleven times – looked at all of it, and decided the right name for the pile was *Praises*.

Either that is a mistake, or it is a claim about where the whole book is going.

Three cautions, and they matter.

The labels do not cover the whole book. Something like a third of the psalms carry no type word at all – no *mizmor*, no *shir*, nothing. Psalm 1 has no heading whatever. If the labels were a filing system somebody would have finished the job.

The headings are ancient, but they are not part of the poem. They come to us with the text and the Jewish tradition counts them as scripture; the Greek translators added to them, which tells you they were already being handled and interpreted a long time ago. So they carry real weight and they are not the psalmist's own signature.

And a label is not a key. Knowing that a psalm is a *maskil* does not tell you what it means. It tells you at what pace to work, and that is all – which is a small thing, and worth having.

Psalm 76, which was my morning reading, just sits on the page. It isn't anything special. Or so it seemed.

So I read the line above it.

To the choirmaster: with stringed instruments. A Psalm of Asaph. A Song.

Two labels, not one. *Mizmor* and *shir* together – strings and voices both. Only a handful of psalms carry the pair, and 75 and 76 sit side by side among them. Whatever this is, it was performed. It was not written to be read quietly by one man at a kitchen table, which is exactly what I was doing with it.

Then the name. Asaph was a Levite, one of three chief musicians David appointed when the ark came to Jerusalem, and the one left before the ark to minister there continually while the others went to Gibeon. Chronicles says his sons prophesied under his hand, and Hezekiah's record calls him *Asaph the seer* – a title, not a compliment.

But the sons of Asaph outlast the man by centuries: a hundred and twenty-eight of them come back from Babylon, still named for him. So "of Asaph" may mean by him, or for his choir, or out of his house. It is a lineage as much as a signature.

And then what the psalm doesn't have. Nothing is asked for. Read its neighbours: 74 pleading in the ruins of the temple, 77 asking whether God's *hesed* has ceased for ever, 79 and 80 both begging. Psalm 76 asks for nothing at all, because it stands after the event rather than inside it.

Which raises the question of what event.

The traditional answer is 701 BC: Sennacherib's army encamped against Jerusalem, and the siege lifting overnight with no battle fought (2 Kings 18–19; Isaiah 37). The Greek translators appear to have read it that way, adding *concerning the Assyrian* to the heading. Read the psalm against that morning and the flat lines sharpen:

There he broke the flashing arrows, the shield, the sword, the weapons of war.

The stouthearted were despoiled; they sank into sleep.

At your rebuke the rider and the horse lay stunned.

The weapons break without anyone in Jerusalem swinging back. The soldiers do not fall in combat; they sleep. Nobody inside the city fought. They woke up and it was over – which is why there is nothing to ask for. You cannot petition for what has already been done to you while you were asleep.

So this is a victory song. And a victory song sung by people who were not at the victory turns into something else: pleasant, historic, and not theirs. That is the honest reason it sits flat. Not because the psalm is weak, but because I came to it looking for something to pray, and it is not a prayer. It is a performance, by a choir, about a morning.

Which is what the label was telling me before I read a word of it.

The heading does not make a dull psalm interesting. It does something more useful and much smaller. It tells you what kind of psalm this is, so you stop asking it to be something else. A *maskil* will not yield to a quick read. A *tephillah* will not preach. And a *mizmor shir* about a battle nobody fought will not do what a lament does, however long you sit with it.

I had been reading the psalms for forty years and taking the line above them as furniture. It was an instruction the whole time.

This article did not begin with artificial intelligence. It began with years of ministry, reading, prayer, suffering, and conversation.

During the development of this article, AI became a conversation partner. It challenged assumptions, tested arguments, suggested structures, and helped refine expression. Many of the words that follow emerged through that dialogue.

The experiences, convictions, interpretations, and conclusions remain my own.